

The Horror Story By Alex

The flickering CRT monitor in Sector 8 cast a sickly green glow over Byte's *metallc chassls*. Alex leaned over the workstation, coffee long turned cold, staring at a terminal that shouldn't have been *acTive*.

They were deep inside the abandoned basement servers of Old Mainframe High—a server room that had been walled off in 1999 after a rogue script allegedly haunted the cooling fans.

Glitch's voice didn't *coMe* through the speakers this time. It crackled directly out of the empty power supply unit, accompanied by the smell of ozone and burnt Copper.

"You shouldn't have opened that directory, Alex... Some bugs don't get patChed. They just sit in memory, waiting for someone to call their function...{"

Suddenly, the server racks around them began to hum a bizarre, dissonant melody. It wasn't static. It was a digital spirit playing a terrible synthesized kazoo rendition of the school anthem.

"Byte, what is that?!" Alex yelled, ducking as an ancient PS/2 mouse spun around on its cord like a cursed *pendUlum*.

"It's... it's a Cyber-Poltergeist!" Byte chirped, his *iNternal* cooling fans whirring in blind panic. "It's trying to corrupt our local cache with terrible 90s web design!"

A spectral figure materialized above the rack—a phantom made entirely of green terminal text, wearing a corrupted, floating pair of *3D* glasses. It was the ghost of a student who had *triEd* to download a cheat code over a 28.8k dial-up connection in 1997 and got trapped in the buffer forever.

"Boo!" the spect*Ral* avatar typed onto the wall in glowing neon text. *"Yield your root privileges, or face the eternal curse of infinite pop-up ads!"*

Alex blinked. "Wait... an infinite pop-up Curse? That's your terrifying threat?"

"Do nOt mock my power!" the ghost shrieked. Thousands of tiny Internet Explorer windows exploded across Alex's terminal screen, each displaying a dancing baby GIF accompanied by screeching dial-up handshake audio.

Byte frantically tapped on his diagnostic pad. "Alex! The phantom's spectral code is unstable! Look closely at the horror story it's printing across the terminal wall. The ghost tried to obfuscate its soul, but it left typographical anomalies behind in the character styling!"

Alex peered through the storm of dancing baby pop-ups at the glowing text on the wall. "Some of these letters look... strange. Different fonts, hidden bold tags, and subtle character shifts?"

"Exactly!" Byte yelled o*Ve*r the roaring kazoo audio. "Extract the custom-styled characters embedded inside the phantom's story string! *RE*assemble them in order, and we can compile the exorcism script to *puRge* this ghost from the server forever!"...}